

Browser Privacy - Technical Terms

This glossary translates and simplifies the technical terms found in the Windows Privacy Browsers Guide into plain English.

Data and Tracking Terms

- **Pipeline / Pipeline of your browsing data:** A continuous, automated flow of information. Think of it like a digital plumbing system that constantly sends your web activity straight from your computer to a company's servers.
- **Telemetry / Background Telemetry:** Automated data collection. It acts like a silent tracker built into software that takes notes on how you use the application and reports those diagnostics and activity usage details back to the developers.
- **Cross-site tracking networks:** Systems used by tracking companies (like advertisers) to follow you from one website to another to see what you are looking at and serve you targeted ads.
- **Tracking pixels / Third-party tracking scripts:** Tiny, invisible pieces of code or graphics embedded in websites that act like digital tripwires, alerting companies and neutralizing privacy tools the moment you load a page.

Browser Engine Terms

- **Layout Engine (Blink/Chromium/Gecko):** The core engine or inner machinery of a web browser. It is the underlying layout engine code responsible for taking raw website data and physically drawing it onto your screen so you can see it.
- **Chromium vs. Non-Chromium:** Chromium is an open-source web browser engine project built by Google that serves as the base for many platforms. Browsers built on this base feel and act just like Google Chrome. Non-Chromium means the browser uses an entirely independent engine (like Mozilla's Gecko) that is completely independent of Google's ecosystem.

Software and Compatibility Terms

- **Framework compatibility / Extension ecosystem:** This means the browser plays nice with Chrome's add-ons. It maintains structural layout compatibility and allows you to install and use the same framework extensions you used in Chrome without any issues.

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- **Binaries:** The actual, pre-compiled software files or code units that make a program run. In this context, "surgical removal of Google binaries" means cutting out the specific pieces of Google's code from the browser.
- **Cloud synchronization dependencies:** Features that connect a browser to a company's online servers to function. For example, a browser relying on this cannot sync your settings or history without sending them to an online cloud account.
- **Pre-loading services / Pre-fetching submission code:** Features where a browser guesses what link you might click next and secretly loads it in the background before you even touch it. While it makes browsing feel faster, it communicates with those background services before you explicitly decide to visit.

Security and Development Terms

- **Total Cookie Protection / Isolating cookies:** A security feature that puts the cookies (small files websites use to remember you) into separate, isolated boxes for each specific site they originated from. This blocks cross-site tracking networks from looking at cookies left behind by other websites.
- **Fork:** A community-driven or alternative software project created by copying the code of an existing program and changing it. For example, [LibreWolf](#) is a "fork" of Firefox configured for maximum privacy by altering the default cloud dependencies and telemetry settings.